PRESS INFORMATION BUREAU
GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

DETERMINATION TO REMOVE INEQUALITIES AND INJUSTICE

PRIME MINISTER REITERATES PLEDGE

CALL TO REMAIN UNITED IN FACE OF NEW CHALLENGES

New Delhi, Sravana 24, 1893
August 15, 1971

Speaking from the ramparts of the Red Fort on the occasion of the 25th Independence Day of the country, the Prime Minister reaffirmed that Government was determined to remove disparities and urged the people to lend a hand in removing social inequalities also.

The Prime Minister referred to the recent legislation for amendment of the Constitution and assured that while the Government was not interested in taking away anything from any one, "we only wish that the benefits of affluence which some of us enjoy should also accrue to the country and its people."

Speaking of the various challenges the country faces today the Prime Minister said that "ours was a policy of peace. We do not rattle our sabres and we do not want war. We do not threaten anyone nor are we scared by anyone's threats. We know that India can face any emergency and that whatever may happen, we will face it with courage and determination."

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Following is the free translation of the Prime Minister's speech:

The month of August has a great significance in the life of our nation. You will recall that we meet here every year not merely to see each other but to salute our flag. It is not merely a piece of cloth but also a symbol of our independence. It is the symbol of our heroes who laid down their lives for independence and of those who are willing to sacrifice their lives even today.

Those of us who assemble here at the Red Fort and many more millions who remain in their homes or in their fields, work in factories or in offices and cannot come here, ask us how much the country has covered towards its goal and how much still remains? In fact the journey of a country never ends. Howsoever, we may move forward, the road gets lengthened and we have to cover that much.

Much has happened in our country during the last year. First of all, I want to thank you for proving wrong what certain people were saying about India and its people in our own country and abroad. You have proved that whatever the difficulties, the people of this country are aware of their rights and their powers. You have proved it in the biggest election ever held in the world; biggest because there is no other country which has as large a population and holds elections. We also proved that despite intimidation, bad weather and even risk of life, you did not desist from exercising your vote. You did not vote for a person or even for a party.

You voted....

farmers and weaker sections of the rural community so that they also can play their full role in the life of the community. They have to be partners in our efforts to improve life in our villages.

We have also a programme to put a ceiling on urban property. We are determined to implement our programmes one after the other. Some of them have already been implemented; while others are still to be implemented. After the General Elections, when your representatives assembled here in Delhi you had very high hopes and so had we. We thought that we will be able to progress rapidly. However, suddenly and for no fault of ours we were burdened with a problem which we had never imagined. But you know that the people of India have been able to carry many burdens and will be able to carry many more in future. We know that the inner strength that our citizens have, whether they are soldiers or civilians, old or young, will enable us to surmount all the difficulties that may come in our way.

I do know that quite a few things have happened that have disturbed you. At the same time many things have happened that have strengthened our hopes. The brave manner in which our people faced many difficulties, carrying various burdens and coming to each other's help has probably given you a sense of pride also. We seek assistance from abroad but ultimately we have to stand on our own feet. We, the citizens of India, have to see that we defend not only our own rights but also the rights of those who are not able to raise their voice. This is a responsibility not of the Government

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but of every citizen. We still suffer from the disparities and inequalities which have afflicted our society for centuries. These disparities gave us a bad name and weaker us. Removal of economic disparities is the responsibility of the State but it is the people who have to remove social inequalities. The great responsibility of uniting India and strengthening the country lies with the people.

Another worry, specially of our women is regarding rising prices. Price spiral affects us all and it should our endeavour that the prices of the essential commonidite come down. However, much of this responsibility can be bo by the people. Why do the prices rise? Sometimes, when a commodity is in short supply, there is a rise in price and it is understandable, but at times when a particular item taxed, other items which are in no way related to it also register a rise in price. Who raises this price and why? You have to investigate it in your own locality and organi yourself to see that this does not happen. You have to consider about your responsibility as citizens whether the be about price rise or any other matter.

You all know that this country has faced many challenges. But the challenge that confronts it today is unparalleled and probably has never been faced by any cou in the world. While we have been striving to give people their rights, the opposite had happened across our border Elections were held there just as elections were held in country. Like in our country people there too came out t vote but where as we have been trying to fulfil our words

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great tragedy has happened there. As a consequence of this tragedy, 7.5 million wounded, sick and starved people have left their homes and hearths and country to take shelter in India. We have always kept our doors open for the displaced persons. But they are not merely refugees; they are partners in a movement which is very significant. It is a movement similar to our own and launched in many other countries to secure the rights of the people. When we talk of the prices, let us not overlook the price these people from Bangla Desh are required to pay for the freedom of their country.

We have thus to keep in our view wider issues. We have to surmount difficulties and not turn a blind eye to them or hide them. The difficulties have to be faced. At the same time we have to consider bigger things. Around us, democracy has failed. A number of countries have scrapped their constitutions. What is there in India that has kept its feet firmly on the grounds of democracy in order to give real meaning to the constitution and make it more useful for the people. This is a tradition we have to safeguard. We have to see that our independence is secured and at the same time our democratic traditions are fully maintained at all times.

You know that our policy has been to carry all our people along with us. Our foreign policy has been the same, a policy of peace. We do not rattle our sabres and we do not want war. We do not raise slogans which will hurt others. But why? It is because we know that our true power lies in our

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people. It lies in our strengthening the country, fortifying its economy and improving its social conditions. This is what is being done with great endeavour. We do not threaten any or nor are we scared by any one's threats. In our hearts we know that India can face any emergency and that whatever may happen we will face it with courage and determination.

We have assembled here today to salute Mother India who has given birth to us and from whom we have inherited a tradition which enables us to face all difficulties boldly and proudly. We have to maintain this spirit always and view everything in this light.

For today's occasion the rain has stopped in time, but you know that in several parts of the country there have been serious floods, while some States are again affected by drought at places there is no water even to drink. Despite all this, there has been enough agricultural production for our people. Only in pulses and oil seeds, there has been some shortfalls. But there is no shortage of foodgrains. However, you know that we have now to feed not only our own people but also substantial number of people who have come from across the border.

Slogans are raised here about Bangla Desh and its great leader. It is a matter about which no one in India or anywhere in the world who has love for independence and humanity can remain quiet. But whatever steps we may take, we have to see whether such steps make us strong or not. Whether such steps or slogans also make those people strong who are involved in their... 8

in their fight for freedom. I can assure you that any step that we may take will be guided by the consideration that wherever there may be fight for freedom or wherever downtrodden may fight for their rights and wherever there is a struggle for the progress of humanity, India and its people will always come out in their support. This is the time, howsoever, critical it may be, we should not feel frustrated. In fact there has never been any reason to feel disheartened. Today when the people have repeatedly proved that in spite of these sufferings and sacrifices involved, we can and we will face difficulties with faith and self-confidence. We are not afraid to face the future.

The wave of change is sweeping this country and other countries as well and no one can remain unaffected by it. This wave will engulf all. However, we do not have to fear it because we are swimming with the current. In fact we are giving a direction to this current and we know that we are ready to face whatever the future may bring us.

On this auspicious day our fullest sympathies are with those of our people who are suffering either because of floods or drought or poverty or some injustice. I say to them - keep your chin up and lend us your hand. We will help you and all of us together will carry out beloved India forward. For the people of India, this is the time to be ready to face whatever difficulties, sufferings, dangers there may be.

The people of India may be poor or illiterate. But such has been this land of heroes and such has been its history

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that we have today no reason either to retreat from the path we have taken or fear that this may not be the right path. We have only to keep one thing in view. Ours has been an old tradition of secularism and we have to remain firm on that.

I have already said that we want to remain friends with everyone. Recently, we entered into a treaty with the Soviet Union. Some people think that as a result of this treaty the has been a change in our policy. There has been no change in our policy because the policy we are following is the one whi is good for this country. It is not as though we cannot ever change our policy. But the policy we have followed is the on which was correct before and is correct today for a country l India. We now see that all countries, whether they admit it are now inclined towards this policy. In fact for countries India no other policy can be of any good. Therefore, we have stick to basic things whether they flow out of our traditions or our modern day politics.

At the same time, we make mistakes and we should be bol enough to accept our mistakes and say that we are ready to c them. Many changes have been brought in our national policy perhaps other changes will also be necessary so that we are to put our poor people on their feet and that together we mal this country strong. World history tells us that a country not progress through the barrel of a gun. A country makes progress only when its people are served well, when they are strong and when the Government is run with their consent.

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This is what we are trying and we hope that you will give us your cooperation. At a time like this, whatever are party or political ideologies, we should be united for the defence of the country, its unity and territorial integrity. We should be able to defend the poor and make the country strong in every way. We will forget about whatever vested interests we may have in a particular slogan. We will have only one slogan and that will be 'Let us be one, let us be courageous and let us march forward'. If we go away from here with this feeling, no one will be able either to stop us or suppress us.

Brothers and sisters, some of you are here in uniforms; many others are without uniforms, but remember that all of us are country's soldiers. We have to resolve that if need be, we will shed our blood and sweat in the defence of our country. We will raise it, as also the entire humanity, to a new height, and that in this task we shall always be in the forefront.

I congratulate you on this auspicious day and hope that we will do much more in the coming year than was done in the last year. We will do it with your cooperation and will move forward rapidly.

Now join me in raising our slogan "Jai Hind, Jai Hind, Jai Hind".

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